

HYDERABAD | Gold Rush



(FROM LEFT) RAO, TTD CHAIRMAN D.K. AUDIKESAVULU AND SBI CHAIRMAN O.P. BHATT

In Gold We Trust' appears to be the new motto of the State Bank of India (SBI) as it begins mopping up the huge resources of the yellow metal piling up in temple vaults. In perhaps one of the largest gold transactions in the world, the bank collected 1,075 kg gold from the Tirumala Tirupathi Devasthanams (TTD) on May 23. TTD Executive Officer IYR Krishna Rao says its 3,000 kg deposit will be handed over to the SBI in phases. The bank already has gold deposits of the Guruvayur and Vaishno Devi temples. Apart from the security and insurance cover, the TTD will also get an annual interest of Rs 8 crore for its 3,000 kg gold. No wonder, the TTD is now contemplating depositing its silver with the SBI too. *by Amarnath K. Menon*

THE SBI RECEIVES ONE OF ITS LARGEST DEPOSITS IN 3,000 KG GOLD.

THE IAF'S FAMED SUKHOI-30MKI FIGHTERS ARE ABOUT TO GET AN UPGRADE.

DELHI | Fierce Fighter

The IAF has begun the 'Super 30' project to upgrade its Sukhoi-30MKI fighters with new radars, mission computers, electronic warfare systems and Brahmos missiles. Recently cleared by the Cabinet Committee on Security, the Sukhoi design bureau will start upgrading two prototypes in Moscow this year. The first two Super 30s will fly into India in 2012 after which upgrades will be incorporated into the last batch of 40 Sukhois being licence-built at HAL, Nasik, from 2015. The IAF operates around 100 Su-30MKIs and will add another 170 in the next decade. *by Sandeep Unnithan*

BANGALORE | The Legend Returns

Thirty-five years after *Sholay* was shot outside Bangalore, an entrepreneur has woken up to the commercial viability of this rocky terrain once ruled by Gabbar Singh—on screen. Despite protests by environmental groups and the Forest Department, Anthara Resorts plans to build an exclusive property in the real Sholay country, Ramanagaram. Never mind a health club, swimming pool and spa, the Ramgarh resort will have waiters dressed as Gabbar Singh. Even as Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa promised to halt the construction, State Home Minister V.S. Acharya wrote to the Forest Department, asking it to "cooperate". While an earlier venture to build Buddha statues in the area had come to naught, Anthara claims that a *Sholay*-inspired resort will help boost tourism. *by Nirmala Ravindran*



Illustration by SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com

MUMBAI | Going Green

The monumental Elephanta Island will soon be lit by green energy. Pune-based Science and Technology Park (STP) has sought the support of an Australian company Solar Gem to light up three electricity-deprived villages on the island. The Australian Government will fund half of the Rs 10-crore project and the rest will be borne by STP and the Mumbai Metropolitan Regional Development Authority. All installations will be done keeping in mind the architecture of the heritage site. In the first phase, one village will get solar street lamps and each house LED lamps and a solar battery. The second phase will see the other two villages getting electricity through wind, solar energy and wood gasifiers. The phase two will also provide cables for air-conditioners and refrigerators in the villages. *by Mitali Patel*